

THE RAMS could have looked at the scoreboard Monday night, congratulated themselves on restoring order and called it an evening.

Davante Adams had spent three hours reminding everyone that he remains a problem without an obvious solution. Matthew Stafford was delivering the ball with conviction. And the misery of Australia finally had some distance behind it.

There was plenty to feel good about.

Feeling satisfied is another matter.

For a team with the Rams' ambitions, Monday's win over the Giants was as much a reminder of what remains possible as evidence of what still needs work.



LA

**Vincent
Bonsignore**

"The cool thing is there's a lot of stuff we can clean up too," Rams coach Sean McVay said.

Cool might not have been his preferred description when the ball was hitting the ground.

But his larger point holds up.

The Rams won 28-6, out-gained the Giants 481-182 and got 327 passing yards and four touchdown throws from Stafford.

And still, there were stretches when they seemed determined to make the evening more complicated than necessary.

Kyren Williams' fumble at the Rams 11-yard line handed the Giants three points. A better opponent might have turned it into a touchdown. Stafford forced a throw into double coverage. Dropped passes turned opportunities into frustrations.

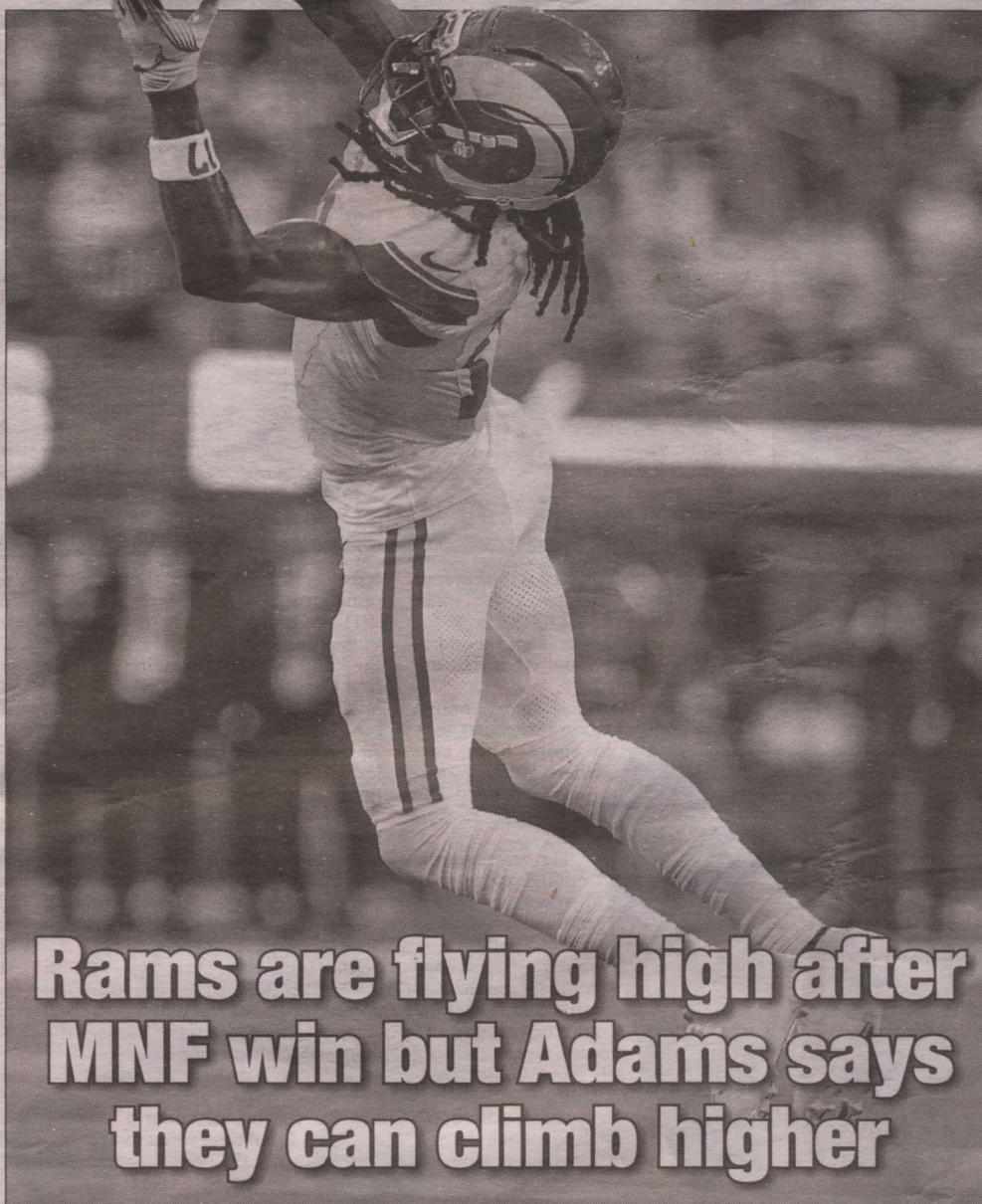
Those are the kinds of mistakes a team can survive against an opponent struggling to generate much of anything. And remember, the Giants played nearly the entire game without quarterback Jaxson Dart, who went down with a knee injury on the opening drive.

It doesn't need to be explained how the calculus changed once he left and James Winston replaced him.

Point being, the mistakes the Rams made Monday become considerably more expensive when the caliber of opponent improves. That starts on Sunday when the Rams head to the Mile High City to play the Broncos.

That distinction belongs in any honest assessment of Monday night. So does the understanding that identifying flaws in a comfortable victory is hardly a reason to panic.

NEXT LEVEL



Rams are flying high after MNF win but Adams says they can climb higher

UP, UP AND AWAY: Star receiver Davante Adams finished with 195 yards on eight receptions with two touchdowns Monday night in the Rams' 28-6 win over the Giants. The performance was a reminder of the talent level the team is playing with and the high bar they have to clear.

Getty Images

It is Week 2.

Nobody hands out trophies for having the cleanest September. And nobody with designs on playing deep into the postseason should want this to be the best version of themselves.

"We were a little bit not as efficient as I would have liked in certain areas," Stafford said. "Some plays that we can make

that we didn't make. We do that, we like where we are, but it was nice to get a win as we're finding a way to be better."

The reassuring part is that the Rams can point to specific ways to improve.

Protect the ball. Finish catches. Give productive possessions a chance to become points instead of explaining afterward

why they did not.

Those corrections do not require discovering an entirely different offense.

They require getting more out of the one already taking shape.

Adams offered the clearest illustration. His eight catches for 195 yards and two touchdowns were enough to dominate the evening. They also invited a big-

ger question.

What might this look like when the Rams stop interrupting themselves?

"I think it was a glimpse of it, to be honest. Because I think we still got another level to tap into," Adams said. "And I don't say that trying to be like 'that' but at the end of the day, if we take care of the ball a little bit better, it's going to equate to more points."

That is a reasonable expectation, especially with Puka Nacua eventually returning to the offense, Aaron Donald still rounding back into form and Myles Garrett expected back on defense eventually.

The Rams are still working toward the lineup they envisioned. Nacua gives Stafford another premier target and defenses another difficult choice. Garrett gives the defensive front another player capable of wrecking a possession.

Their returns will raise the possibilities.

The work in the meantime is making sure those stars rejoin a team that has improved its habits, rather than one waiting for reinforcements to solve everything.

There is an important difference.

"Obviously, we're happy about it, any win in this league is one to celebrate," Adams said. "But when you're trying to be great and a Super Bowl-caliber team, you have to hold yourself to a high standard, and I think we can do a little better."

Adams' standard is the appropriate one.

The Rams needed a win after Australia. They also needed evidence that the team they expected to be was still there, beneath the mistakes and the early disruption.

Monday supplied both.

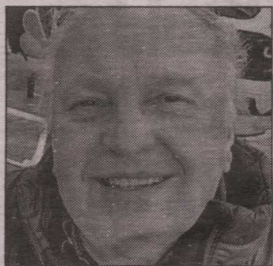
Now comes the less glamorous business of turning an encouraging performance into something dependable. The catches that must be finished. The possessions that must be protected. The decisions that cannot be excused simply because the final margin was comfortable.

There is plenty to clean up.

In September, with a win in hand and another level within reach, that is a perfectly acceptable place to be.

Provided the Rams keep climbing.

vbonsignore@californiapost.com



GEORGE MARCINIW
Doomed NBC chopper ace.

Tragic report on NBC heli pilot

The cause of death for the pilot in the NBC news helicopter crash has been revealed.

George Marciniw died of blunt force trauma after the aircraft fell from the sky near a Chatsworth warehouse last Tuesday, according to the LA County Medical Examiner. He was 70.

Reporter Eliana Moreno's death was also the result of blunt force trauma, the medical examiner reported on Monday. She was 38.

A third victim, 29-year-old bystander Edy Gutierrez Mejia, died of blunt head trauma.

The cause of the helicopter crash remains under investigation by the National Transportation Safety Board and the Federal Aviation Administration.

An NTSB investigator called the aircraft's live news video the "most important evidence" they had discovered so far.

Investigator-in-charge Fabian Salazar said the NTSB wants a "pristine copy" of the recording so it can be subjected to a sound-spectrum analysis at the agency's laboratory.

"In that recording, we are clearly hearing sounds that are consistent with the engine changing its speed, and we're also hearing tones that are being generated that are likely advisories to the pilot," Salazar said at a press conference last week.

The Metro bus collision the pair were covering claimed the lives of 31-year-old Gage Weida and 46-year-old father of four Daniel Castillo, 46. The medical examiner ruled both died from "multiple blunt traumatic injuries." Ross O'Keefe

Surprise live show at MacArthur BIEBER'S LARK AT L.A. PARK



OH, 'BABY': Justin Bieber, who headlined Coachella earlier this year, plays a slightly smaller venue — drug-infested MacArthur Park — on Tuesday with a small group of musicians. The pop star played a few of his unreleased tracks for those lucky enough to hear.



By PIERCE SHAPRE

Justin Bieber turned LA's most infamous park into a surprise stage Tuesday when he turned up at MacArthur Park for an impromptu performance.

A space typically known for its drug use and trash got a break from the grime as the singer broke into a casual live set, drawing the attention of those nearby.

Bieber performed surprise and unreleased tracks including "Speed Demon," "All I Can Take" and "Yukon," giving an unexpected taste of what he's been working on.

The low-key appearance was a far cry from the singer's usual arena-sized productions, with Bieber appearing to simply drop in, perform and mingle at the park.

He headlined Coachella earlier this year, drawing a massive crowd for a career-spanning set that included songs from his recent albums as well as throwbacks like "Baby," "Never Say Never" and "Beauty and a Beat."

The festival marked one of Bieber's biggest live appearances since largely stepping away from touring in 2022.

Bieber may not be a total stranger to MacArthur Park. In 2021, the hitmaker surprised students at the nearby MacArthur Park Visual and Performing Arts Elementary with a mini-concert, performing his songs "Intentions" and "Holy" as part of a back-to-school event.

'I wish i was there!!!!'

Videos from the surprise performance quickly circulated.

"He chose the place where not many girls were gonna be at omg!!!! I wish i was there!!!!" one user commented.

"It's wild to think that Justin is one of the few celebrities who does this out in the open," another person wrote. "I'm really happy for the people who witnessed it."

Earlier this month, LA County's top prosecutor hosted a picnic in the park, a promise he made as part of an effort to "clean up" the notorious spot back in June.

At least 37 people have been arrested across major joint federal and local drug operations at MacArthur Park this year.